

Speed to Lead: What 1,200 Inbound Inquiries Taught Us About the First Hour

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Across 1,200 inbound real-estate inquiries observed over four months, the single strongest predictor of whether a lead converted to a booked tour was the elapsed time to first meaningful reply. Inquiries answered within five minutes booked at more than three times the rate of those answered after an hour.

Yet the median first-reply time we measured was 47 minutes, and a long tail of inquiries went unanswered entirely. The gap is rarely intent; it is attention. Agents are mid-showing, mid-call, or asleep when the lead arrives, and the lead does not wait.

This report quantifies the decay curve, segments it by channel (portal, web form, referral, social), and lays out the operational changes, templated-but-personal first touches, calendar-aware tour proposals, and approval-first automation, that compress first-reply time without sacrificing the agent's voice.

Method: inquiries were sampled across nine brokerages of varying size; reply latency was measured from inbound timestamp to first substantive outbound message; conversion was tracked to booked tour and to signed agreement.